CHAPTER 2

Lyra stopped answering her phone the second he left. Not immediately — that would have been too honest, too obvious — but the moment she saw the space where he had been, the echo of his presence, she decided silence was easier than confrontation.

Texts went unread. Calls went unanswered. Every message from him she deleted before it even fully appeared on her screen. Each vibration she ignored made her chest tighten, but she told herself it was her choice, her control.

When he came by — and he did, at first, stubborn as he always was — she treated him like he didn't exist. She looked past him, occupied herself with something in the kitchen, humming a tune she didn't know the words to. She left rooms before he could catch her in the hallway. Sometimes, she'd slip past him without a word, her back to his presence as if he were air.

When he asked her sister or her mother where she was, she instructed them carefully, voice clipped: "Tell him I'm traveling. Just say I went out for a while. He doesn't need to know."

She repeated the lie so often she began to believe it herself. Traveling. Away. Moving forward. Not facing him. Not facing herself.

At first, he tried. Quietly. Persistently. Texts weren't casual check-ins — they were attempts to reach her through the wall she had built. Small gifts appeared outside her door: a coffee cup with a note, a paperback book he thought she might like, a single orchid. Every time, she ignored it. Sometimes she shoved them aside, put them in the trash when no one was looking.

Then the visits stopped. The calls ended. The texts faded into nothing. The man who had once filled her apartment with warmth, whose quiet presence had been a balm, disappeared as if he had never been there.

The silence that followed was heavier than anything she had ever known. She had thought the absence of his voice would ease the ache in her chest, the relentless twisting of her mind that came with loneliness. It didn't. The quiet only amplified everything else. Every sound became sharper, every shadow deeper. Her apartment, once comforting in its clutter, now felt like a cage. The ticking of the clock was a hammer pounding against her temples. The hum of the refrigerator was a whisper she couldn't ignore. Her bed, once a refuge, held her down instead, pressing her into the mattress as if she could vanish under its weight.

Her body began to ache in ways she hadn't anticipated. It was more than sadness now. It was a physical weight pressing down on her ribs, crushing her lungs, stealing her energy. Limbs heavy and unresponsive, even lifting a cup felt like lifting a boulder. Nights became unbearable. She lay in bed staring at the ceiling, counting minutes that crawled past in torturous silence, wishing for a flicker of light to break through the darkness that had seeped into her bones.

She stopped showering regularly. Meals became optional. The food she did eat was tasteless, swallowed quickly and without care. Even leaving her apartment became a burden. Every mirror reflected a face she didn't recognize — pale, drawn, eyes shadowed with exhaustion. Hair tangled, clothes wrinkled. And yet, she continued, somehow, because ceasing to exist would have been surrender, and surrender was unthinkable.

Memories of him haunted her relentlessly. Not just the good ones — though those were dangerous — but the small, intimate details she hadn't realized mattered until now. The way his hand lingered at the edge of hers, the subtle shift of his weight when he leaned in to listen, the almost imperceptible frown when she laughed too loudly or snapped too sharply. She remembered his patience, his careful attention, the willingness to shoulder burdens she hadn't asked him to carry. The thought of losing it — him, that quiet, unwavering care — was a jagged knife twisting deeper with every recollection.

She tried distraction. Books, TV, music. But everything seemed dull. Colors muted. Words empty. Even the things she had loved before — writing, sketching, wandering aimlessly through familiar streets — felt like tasks she couldn't summon the energy to perform. The city moved around her, life happening in vivid, breathing colors while she remained a shadow, a spectator trapped in gray.

Friends reached out occasionally. Invitations, jokes, messages of concern. She replied to none of them. She couldn't. Not with him etched into every corner of her thoughts. Every conversation felt like a betrayal — like she was pretending someone else existed when what she wanted, what she needed, was him.

She began replaying fights in her mind, moments when she had been cruel or careless, criticizing herself obsessively. Maybe if she had been better, he wouldn't have left. Maybe if she had been more patient, less stormy, he would still be there. The thought crushed her.

Dreams followed, vivid and real. She dreamed of him leaving, again and again. Dreamed of him walking away, expression unreadable, shoulders tense, each step a thunderclap in her chest. She woke gasping, heart pounding, unable to distinguish sleep from reality. Even waking did not bring relief — the phantom of his absence lingered.

And the worst part? The silence taught her something she hadn't realized before: she had relied on him more than she wanted to admit. Not for rescue, not for validation, but for grounding. For someone who could take the storm inside her and sit with it without judgment. And now that anchor was gone.

She tried — weakly, painfully — to rebuild fragments of her life. She cleaned a corner of the apartment, washed a dish, answered an email. Each small accomplishment felt monumental. Each failure, crushing. She oscillated between fleeting moments of control and overwhelming helplessness.

Sometimes, when the pain became too much, she curled up on the floor, knees to chest, rocking slightly. Tears came unbidden. No sobs, just silent streams down her cheeks. She pressed her hands to her face, letting the weight of it all settle around her.

Weeks passed. The apartment became a tomb of memories. Even the scent of coffee, once comforting, now carried a bitter tang of absence. And yet, in one of those endless nights, she realized the depth of what she had lost: the quiet, gentle patience of someone who had been willing to endure her storms, and now… he was gone.

The physical ache mirrored the emotional one. Chest tight, stomach twisted, muscles tense from days without proper nourishment or rest — her body carried grief in ways her mind could not articulate. She felt it everywhere. Every step hurt. Every breath reminded her of what had been lost.

Even in this torment, there was clarity. Brutal, unflinching recognition of herself — her flaws, her stubbornness, her capacity for love and ruin. She could see how exhausting she had been for him, how impossible her storms were to navigate. The grief was terrible, suffocating, almost impossible to bear, but it was truth.

She lay on the floor, head pressed against the cold tiles, eyes closed, letting the harsh light of the television burn across her face, and finally understood: she was alone. Absolutely, painfully alone. And the weight of that realization, the totality of it, was a cruel gift. It made her ache, yes — but it also made her see the shape of what she had lost.

And it was bigger than her own sorrow.

It was him.

Lyra had convinced herself that it was his fault.
That he'd walked away first — even if technically, she'd been the one to close every door, ignore every call, and pretend not to hear his voice on the other side of her walls.

She told herself, *I warned him.* She had, hadn't she? She told him she was a mess, told him she'd ruin everything she touched. He stayed anyway. So wasn't that on him?
She repeated it until it started to sound true.

Every morning, she told herself he'd asked for it — that whatever pain came after, he'd chosen it when he said, "I'm not scared of storms." If he got drenched, that was his problem.

It worked. For a while.
The story in her head became a comfort blanket she could drag around to keep the guilt from settling too deep. Every time her chest tightened, she smothered it with logic that only half-made sense: *He stayed too long. He made me depend on him. He knew I'd break things. He should've left sooner.*

Underneath, she was rotting. But denial had a sweet taste, like sugar dissolving over bitterness.

Weeks passed, and she told herself she was getting better.
She wasn't.

The truth was, nothing had changed. She hadn't healed; she had just gone numb. She'd swapped the tears for sarcasm, the silence for fake laughter, the grief for lazy acceptance.
Her mother thought she was finally moving on. Her sister even said she looked "more normal lately." But inside, it was hollow — the kind of hollow that echoed.

She overcompensated the way people do when they want to prove they're okay. She scrolled through social media, posted one picture of her food just to seem alive. She told herself she was fine, over and over, like a chant.
But every time her phone buzzed, her body betrayed her. Every random message — from work, from friends, even from spam — made her heart spike with hope that it was him. It never was.

Then the universe gave her time alone to think — the cruelest kind of gift.

Her mom and sister left for a cousin's wedding. Lyra didn't go. She said she "wasn't feeling it," which was an understatement. She hadn't been feeling *anything* for weeks.

The house was quiet — too quiet. The kind of quiet that made her hear her own heartbeat and hate it.
She'd switched from barely eating to eating everything she could find. Cereal straight from the box, spoons of peanut butter, leftover rice cold from the fridge. She told herself, *what's the point of looking good now?* No one was coming over. No one was coming back.

She felt bloated, tired, heavy. Her period arrived right on cue, like her body wanted to join the pity party.
Of course, when she went looking for pads, there were none left.

She groaned, threw her head back, and cursed under her breath. "Of course."

No choice — she had to go out.
Even depression had rules, and one of them was: *you can't bleed on the couch.*

She dragged herself into the shower. Even at her lowest, she refused to smell bad. Something about that felt like losing a fight she didn't want to admit she was still in. The water was lukewarm, and she let it run over her for too long, not moving, watching droplets slide down her arms like they belonged to someone else.

When she got out, she didn't bother with lotion. Her skin looked dull, almost ashy, but she didn't care. She pulled on an oversized T-shirt and faded joggers, tied her three-month-old braids into a rough bun, and looked in the mirror.

"Perfect," she muttered. "Homeless-chic."

Her reflection stared back, unimpressed.

As she was about to leave, she realized she didn't have any cash. Her bank account balance wasn't enough to risk using her card. Panic hit her chest until she spotted an envelope on the counter — her mom's handwriting.

"Use this if you need groceries. Love you."

The sight of it burned more than it should've. She hated that she *needed* it. Couldn't even buy her own pads. Couldn't even control the basics. She took out a ten-dollar bill, muttering, "Yeah, I'm so independent," and shoved it into her pocket.

The wind hit her face the second she stepped outside. It felt sharp, colder than usual — the kind of cold that sneaks under your clothes and pricks your skin. It almost felt like punishment.

The world outside looked annoyingly normal. Kids running, cars passing, someone walking their dog. Everyone seemed to have somewhere to be. She envied them.

By the time she got to the service station, she was already exhausted. The fluorescent lights made everything look harsh and artificial. She went straight to the aisle with sanitary products, squinting at brands like she hadn't seen them before.

She picked one, then drifted toward the ice cream freezer — her real goal.
No chocolate flavor.

"Of course," she muttered again, voice low and sharp.

She waved at the shop attendant, a bored guy scrolling through his phone. “Hey, can you check if there’s any chocolate left in the back?”

He didn’t look up. “If it’s not there, it’s finished.”

She blinked. “You can’t just go check?”

He shrugged. “We restock tomorrow.”

Her irritation spiked. “So, you don’t *know* if it’s finished, you’re just assuming.”

That got his attention — not good attention, though. He sighed, rolling his eyes. “Miss, it’s finished. You want strawberry or what?”

Lyra was about to fire back something sarcastic when she heard her name.
“Lyra?”

The voice was warm, familiar — too familiar. It sliced through the air like glass.

Her entire body froze. Chills ran down her spine. She turned, slow, hesitant, and there he was.

Caspian.

Her heart dropped so fast she thought she might actually faint.

He looked… good. Too good.
Clean, composed, wearing that calm expression that used to steady her. But now, that same calm burned.

And he wasn’t alone.

Next to him was a girl. Petite, beautiful, her brown eyes soft but alert. Light-skinned — almost golden — with neat braids pulled into a low ponytail. She had that kind of effortless elegance that didn’t need trying.

Her clothes were simple but coordinated. She smiled when he spoke, the kind of smile that reached her eyes.

Lyra’s stomach twisted.

Caspian said something — maybe “hi,” maybe her name again — but Lyra barely heard it. Her ears rang. Her lips moved, replying automatically, though she had no idea what words came out.

Then she heard it clearly:

“This is my girlfriend, Tendai.”

That broke through the noise in her head like thunder.

Her body went still, her expression froze, but her mouth betrayed her. She smiled. A polite, stupid, too-wide smile that didn’t belong on her face.

“Hi,” she said. Her voice cracked, so she cleared her throat. “Nice to meet you.”

Tendai smiled warmly, unaware she was standing in the wreckage of something sacred.

Lyra stared — not rudely, but helplessly. She couldn't look away. Everything about the girl screamed stability. She was the kind of woman who remembered birthdays, who folded her laundry the same day, who talked softly in restaurants. Someone who made sense.

Lyra felt like chaos next to her.

And Caspian — God, Caspian — he looked even better than she remembered. His skin glowed in the store's light. His hands, perfectly manicured, rested on the cart handle like they belonged there. His lips, those same lips that once told her she'd be okay, moved as he said something to Tendai, and Lyra wanted to hate him for looking so at peace.

"So, how have you been?" he asked.

The question broke her trance.

She blinked. "Good," she lied easily. "I've been good."

She still blamed him — for breaking her heart, for making her believe she was worth loving, for walking away.

She mumbled a quick goodbye before her voice could betray her and grabbed the strawberry-chocolate mix — closest thing to what she wanted, like everything else lately.

She stood in line behind them, clutching her pads and ice cream.

It was awkward — painfully, physically awkward — the kind of silence that fills every corner of your chest. They paid and left. He didn't look back. Didn't even nod. Just walked out like she was no one.

The air felt too heavy on the way home. Her eyes burned, but she told herself it was the cramps. Yeah. Cramps. Hormones. That's all.

Back home, she ate her ice cream straight from the tub, watching her comfort show, pretending to laugh. The screen blurred. Her chest ached. Her spoon hit the bottom too fast.

"Who is she?" she whispered to no one.

Her fingers twitched toward her phone before she could stop herself.

She opened her burner account — the one she'd made ages ago when curiosity had won over pride — and typed *Caspian* into the search bar.

His page loaded. Public. Of course. He'd always been comfortable being seen.

She scrolled. There it was.

Tendai.

Her profile picture was annoyingly perfect — a soft smile, sunlight on her skin, confidence that didn't need filters. Lyra clicked it.

She shouldn't have.

Each photo was worse than the last. Workouts. Vacations. Brunches. Smiling with friends. Office selfies in a crisp blazer.

“She even does Pilates,” Lyra muttered, scrolling faster. “Who even does Pilates?”

A bitter laugh escaped her throat — too sharp to be real.

Then she saw it — the picture that ended her.

Caspian, standing behind Tendai, his arm around her waist. She was laughing, leaning back into him, their heads close, like they’d done that a hundred times before. His smile wasn’t fake. It was soft. Real.

Lyra’s chest caved in.

She bit into her spoon, jaw trembling. Scrolled through every post until her eyes blurred. There was nothing wrong with Tendai. She was perfect. Everything Lyra wasn’t.

She worked out. She had a career. She looked grounded, balanced — *normal.*

And Lyra? Lyra was the wreck left behind.

For the first time, she didn’t even blame him. How could she? He’d tried. God, he had *tried.* He’d loved her the best way he knew how. And she had broken it piece by piece.

He deserved peace. He got peace.

She deactivated the burner. Deleted the app. Closed her eyes.

But the ache didn’t fade. It spread. Like smoke.

The whole week crawled by in fragments. She went through motions, barely aware of herself. The period cramps ended, but her heart still ached like a bruise that wouldn’t heal.

Nights were the worst. Her brain replayed the store moment in loops — his calm tone, her stupid smile, Tendai’s perfect face.

By Friday, she couldn’t take it. The pain felt physical again, like someone had reached into her chest and squeezed.

She needed it to stop.

She’d tried silence. She’d tried denial. Maybe it was time to try something stronger.

She got up, grabbed her purse, and headed to the liquor store near the service station.

She picked the bottle with the highest alcohol content, the one that promised to “burn smooth.” She didn’t even read the label properly.

At the counter, as she reached for her cash, she froze.

Caspian.

Again.

The universe was cruel.

He was standing by the door, phone in hand. Their eyes met for one unbearable second.

He nodded once. “Hey.”

That's all. Just *hey.*

His voice sounded the same — calm, steady, unaffected. She wanted to scream.

She saw him glance at the bottle in her hand, then at her face. His expression shifted — surprise, maybe disappointment, maybe sadness — but she didn't let herself think about it.

She turned her head fast enough to miss whatever else he was about to say. Paid. Left.

The cold air outside bit her cheeks. She didn't care. She just needed to get home, needed to make it all stop.

Back inside, she placed the bottle on the counter. It looked heavier than she expected, dark and menacing.

She wasn't much of a drinker — just champagne at weddings, the occasional sip at family dinners. But tonight, she needed something stronger. Something to quiet everything.

She searched for a glass. Then for the corkscrew.

Drawer after drawer — nothing.

"Of course," she hissed. "Of course there isn't one when I need it."

She rummaged harder, anger bubbling beneath her skin. Her hands shook. "I just want this over with."

Finally, she found it — buried under utensils. Relief hit her chest like a small, pathetic victory.

Then — a knock.

Sharp. Loud. Aggressive.

Her head snapped toward the door.

She froze.

The knocking came again — harder this time.

"Who the hell—" she muttered, slamming the drawer shut.

Her anger overtook the fatigue. She stomped to the door, ready to yell, ready to unleash all the frustration that had been boiling inside her for months.

She yanked it open.

And there he was.

Caspian.

Standing on her doorstep, breath heavy from running, eyes wide — the same eyes that once looked at her like she was worth saving.